



Asian edge: Japan became the first side besides the host nations to qualify for the 2026 FIFA World Cup after a hard-fought 2-0 win over Bahrain. AFP

nations managed without them. Argentina edged Uruguay in a narrow 1-0 win with Thiago Almada scoring the decisive goal, while Brazil beat Colombia 2-1 thanks to goals from Raphinha and Vinicius Junior.

Neymar's career, both with club and country, has been extremely injury-marred. The Sao Paulo local had been out of international action since October 2023, mostly due to injuries. Since his debut for the Canarinha in 2010, Brazil has played 65 matches without him (either on the bench or not in the squad due to suspensions or injury). In those fixtures, the side has had a win

record of 55 per cent (winning 36 matches).

As for Argentina, Messi too has been extremely important for the national team's triumphs in recent tournaments like the 2022 FIFA World Cup and multiple Copa America titles. However, the side has also fared quite well without him. Since his international debut in 2005,

Argentina has played 68 matches without Messi. In those, the side has had a commendable win percentage of 60 (winning 41 matches). The numbers show that Brazil depends on Neymar's 'Joga Bonito' brand of football slightly more than Argentina does on Messi's sublime play. How things pan out in the near future, only time will tell.



Mauricio Pochettino had a CONCACAF Nations League campaign to forget as the USA succumbed to a shock 1-0 defeat against underdogs Panama in the semifinal.